

Use Compliment Postcards To Create Safety

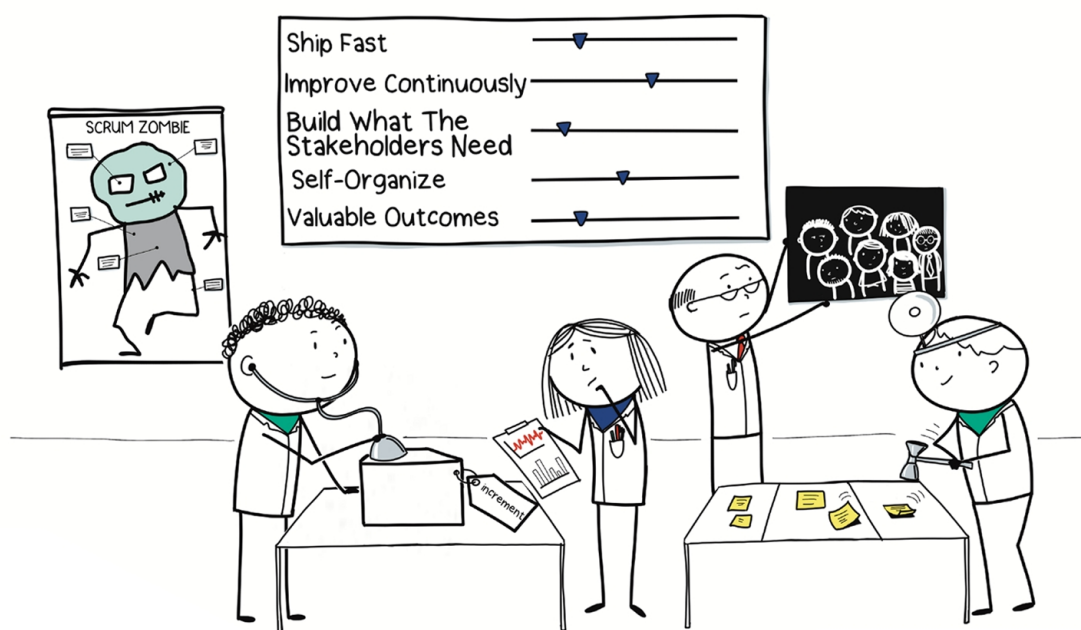
A simple experiment to improve team morale and psychological safety by recognizing the contributions of others



Purpose Of This Experiment

Continuous improvement is the lifeblood of Scrum Teams. But Scrum Teams that lack psychological safety find it hard to learn and improve. Both require trying new things and talking openly about mistakes.

One way to create a safe environment is to help teams recognize and appreciate helpful contributions as they happen. This doesn't always come naturally, and this experiment is designed to help teams learn how to do this. This experiment was inspired by a Scrum Master we worked with – Barry Meijer – and has similarities with Management 3.0's excellent Kudo Cards.



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Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill



Filling in a compliment card isn't hard if you set the example.

Impact On Survival



Being more appreciative of what people contribute is a simple – but very important – way to get out of Zombie Scrum.

Steps

To implement this experiment, do the following:

1. Get a set of empty postcards. We always like to bring cards with motivational texts, odd pictures, and other nice encouragements. You can also switch for the aforementioned Kudo Cards.
2. At the end of a Scrum Event, give people an opportunity to fill in a compliment postcard for someone else who was present. This is optional. Encourage people to look for moments when someone else contributed to the team's ability to learn and grow. For example, when someone shared an intriguing observation, raised a thought-provoking question, or did something out of their comfort zone. The Sprint Retrospective, Sprint Planning, and the Sprint Review are the most natural opportunities.
3. Give everyone the opportunity to give the postcard to the person they wrote it for. Afterward, collect the postcards somewhere in the team room.
4. Leave a stack of compliment cards in the team room for use when an opportunity presents itself. Whenever someone fills in a postcard, they give it to the person it is for. Afterward, add the postcard to the existing set in the team room.

Our Findings

- Only honest compliments matter. Instead of making this an obligatory activity for the whole team to sit through, let people write compliment cards during breaks or after the event. This reduces the peer pressure to write cards "because everyone else is doing it".
- Model the desired behavior as the initiator of this experiment. Make an effort to appreciate contributions that may not seem helpful at first glance, but do help the team learn and grow. For example: taking a personal risk by gently challenging a decision that the majority of a team agrees with or admitting to a mistake.
- When you work with virtual teams, you can replace physical compliment postcards with virtual ones. For example, you can create a #complimentcard channel in Slack or share a simple template that people can fill in.

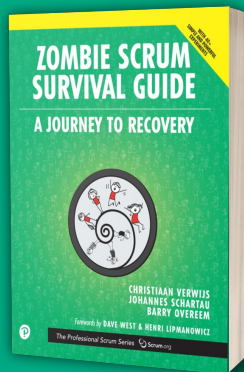
More Resources

- Tool: [You can also give taco's](#) when you want to recognize someone's contribution (thanks to Rasheed Raya for setting the example).
- Tool: [Kudo Cards](#), created by Management 3.0, are also a nice way to show appreciation.

Help Us With Your Feedback

We are eager to learn how this experiment benefitted your team. What did it make possible? With your data, we can improve our recommendations to other teams. You can share [your feedback](#) here with us in a only few minutes.

The Zombie Scrum Survival Guide



Zombie Scrum is on the rise! What may look like Scrum from a distance often turns out to be anything but when you take a closer look. Although teams go through the motions of Scrum, Sprints don't result in valuable outcomes, customers are not involved, teams have little autonomy and nobody is doing anything to improve.

A detailed examination of Zombie Scrum

In our book, we share our research and experience in the field with Zombie Scrum. We explore symptoms and causes, and dig deep into why Zombie Scrum usually starts when the purpose of Scrum isn't clear. With our book, the purpose of Scrum was never this clear!

Start your recovery tomorrow

The good news is that recovery is entirely possible. Our book contains over 40 practical experiments to start recovery, even when your organization has succumbed to it completely.

Get your copy now

You can find the 'Zombie Scrum Survival Guide' in your favorite bookstore starting from November 23, 2020. Or buy your copy from us at zombiescrum.org. The book comes with a free digital first aid kit, and a nice discount for a physical kit.



The Zombie Scrum Resistance

The 'Zombie Scrum Survival Guide' is written by Christiaan Verwijns, Johannes Schartau and Barry Overeem, and richly illustrated by Thea Schukken.

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